

ORGANIZING YOUR SPEECH

An introduction

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Introduction:

Speech organization is effectively taking the information one wishes to present and arranging it in a logical order. It comes down to two things: credibility and audience understanding.

You want your speech to be organized because it will be more enjoyable, easier to understand and add credibility to both you and the speech itself. People will also remember the information better if it is organized

Organization strategy

There is a strategy for ensuring your speech is easy to follow and understand. Information that is organized using a main idea followed by main points and other details is easier to understand.

Main Idea: Your speech should begin with a main idea or the central purpose of the speech. Having a main idea allows you to immediately focus your speech. Think about what you want the audience to walk away with. This will drive every other thing about your speech.

Main Points: These are the smaller chunks of information your speech will be broken down into. These should reinforce your main idea. Include at least two or three main points. Depending on the purpose and audience, you don't want to have more than five main points, so your speech does not get confusing.

Supporting materials: These are the pieces of information you use to flesh out your speech, such as statistics, stories, visual aids etc to "support" your ideas.

Patterns of Organization: These are the different ways you can order/arrange your speech. Note that this will be determined by the purpose of your speech.



1. Chronological order:

This is used where the information should be ordered in stages. It refers to an organizational pattern for speeches in which the main points are arranged in time order. It can be used for processes or timelines.

2. Spatial order:

This is used when the information can be grouped in terms of space or direction. This can be used for regions, such as East, West, North or South; or top, middle and bottom.

3. Topics/Parts of a whole:

This is an all-purpose method and can be used for different types of speeches. It is used for main points that naturally divide into "types of," "kinds of," "sorts of," or "categories of." Other subjects naturally divide into "parts of the whole."

4. Others

These include problem/solution (where a problem is discussed and then possible solutions), cause/effect (where a phenomenon is discussed and the results of such are then discussed) and comparison method.

Connective statements

Since every speech contains more than one main point, it is necessary to strategically make connections between one point and another. Connectives or "connective statements" are designed to help "connect" parts of your speech to make it easier for audience members to follow. They are methods for helping the audience listen, retain information, and follow your structure.

Connectives in general perform a number of functions:

- Remind the audience of what has come before
- Remind the audience of the central focus or purpose of the speech
- Forecast what is coming next
- Help the audience have a sense of context in the speech—where are we?
- Explain the logical connection between the previous main idea(s) and next one or previous subpoints and the next one
- Explain your own mental processes in arranging the material as you have
- Keep the audience's attention through repetition and a sense of movement

Types of connectives

1. **Internal summary:** To emphasize what has been said and remind the audience of what has been covered. E.g. "So far, we've covered the meaning of connectives".

2. **Internal preview:** To emphasize what is coming up next in the speech and what to expect regarding the content. E.g "In the next part, we will discuss the types of connectives".

3. **Transition:** a type of connective that serves as a bridge between disconnected (but related) material in a speech E.g. "Now that we have looked at how to organise your speech, we will now discuss use of connectives"

4. **Signposts:** This is a type of connective that emphasizes physical movement through the speech content and lets the audience know exactly where they are; commonly uses terms such as First, Second, Finally.

Tips for using connectives

There is no standard format, you can use any selection or combination that works best to help your audience move with your flow, understand your logic, or keep their attention.

- Connectives are for connecting; they are not supporting materials
- They can (and ideally, should) be relatively short – not more than a sentence or two.
- You should plan for connectives when preparing and outlining your speech.
- Vary your connectives and don't use the same one all the time.
- Connectives can be used to connect any of the points in your speech, including subpoints, introduction, conclusion and should not be limited to main points only.